



performances and find they have wasted their money. When a franchise picks a player for crores and then doesn't play him in more than a couple of games, it tells you that their scouts and advisers have sold them a dummy.

The IPL very quickly finds a player out as being overrated and overvalued. Yet there will be players who will have one performance in the tournament, and it's usually in a match of not much consequence for their team, and on the basis of that performance, they will be picked for another year. One could make at least four teams of such one-match performers, who will be picked again and again in the IPL.

Rishabh Pant stepping down as the captain of his team, which finished bottom of the table, is the first change in captaincy for the next season, as there could well be many more before the new season starts next year. He did say on more than one occasion that there were too many voices in his ear and too many thought processes, which is definitely not a compliment to the support staff.

Whether that leads to a wholesale change at the franchise will be interesting to see.

Talk is easy, and it is cheap too, and making big claims like some coaches have may make good headlines, but cricket has a funny way of biting on the backside.

Binding force: According to the author, Rajat Patidar's leadership skills got Royal Challengers Bengaluru to gel well as a unit. VIJAY SONEJI

Andy Flower, the coach of RCB, which has now won two back-to-back titles, is a fine example of someone who works quietly, with no big statements that make headlines. And no golfing and beer-drinking buddies as members of his support staff either.

Maybe there's a lesson there. If only those who appoint them could see that, then their teams would not be out of contention even before the first month of the tournament is over.



Captaincy can flower if the individual is doing well in his own speciality, and that is where perhaps Riyan Parag fell a bit short. With his own form not being consistent and with a leg injury at the back of his mind, he wasn't able to lead with the sharpness that one associates with his game.